herself up physically. She could not get into her own tennis gear and instead wore Brij Bedi's (Kiran's husband) shorts and T-shirt for the match. It was almost as if she had been out-of-sorts with herself for letting the woman in her act as an impediment to business at hand. She seemed to have a point to prove and splendidly did she do it.

'To me what is important in life is not being just a police officer but the fact that I am in a position where I can sufficiently provide for myself my mental and physical food. It is this position that enables me to evaluate issues and decide for myself and subsequently enjoy or suffer the consequences without apportioning blame. I have sought for and got the position where I can now give and share always and do not have to ask, seek or wait to get. It is this basic drive to achieve that I would call the foundation of my being. In my case, I have pondered over this quite often and tried to discover the conscious and unconscious manner that it was nurtured in me,' says Kiran Bedi, while fondly showing some letters that she has received from girls and boys from across the country who hold her as their role model.

She definitely possesses a compelling streak of independence and the dogged determination to achieve her objectives, *as a woman*, despite the male-dominated history of her family (and also much of Indian society).

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Kiran was born into a predominantly patriarchal joint family with paternal roots in Peshawar (now in Pakistan) but which later settled in Amritsar. Her great-great-grandfather, Lala Hargobind, a veritable Pathan, came to Amritsar from Peshawar. He set up a carpet manufacturing unit and a utensil factory here and prospered. He started off with Rs 50,000 and, during his lifetime itself, increased his assets twentyfold. He left behind enough property and wealth to enable the succeeding Peshawarias to not only expand their business but also prosper. Her great-grandfather, Lala Chajjumal, was a simple and god-fearing man, but her grandfather, Lala Muni Lal, was something else again. At the age of twelve he dropped out of school and took private tuitions in English for about four years. He related more to his grandfather and borrowed Rs 50,000 from the latter to set up business in the early years of the twentieth century. He opened his offices above his father's wholesale cloth shop and corresponded with manufacturers in the UK in the English that he had learned so assiduously. Very soon he began importing the finest muslin cloth, the famous '926 *mulmul*', from Manchester and grey and white Italian flannel from Bradford. He also purchased a dry, unused pond and constructed a *dharamsala* (rest house for pilgrims) over it that he dedicated to his religiously inclined father. Today, there are Peshawaria *dharamsalas* in holy cities such as Hardwar, Banaras (now called Varanasi), Vrindavan and Amritsar, run by a family trust of the Peshawarias.

Lala Muni Lal was a self-made man, and a headstrong patriarch to boot. He exercised his rights over his family and its properties like a true autocratic *karta* (meaning creator). He was fond of a good life and spent considerable amounts of money on himself but held the purse strings tight for the rest of the large joint family, to whom he gave only a pittance of an allowance for working in the family business. He was only the third man in Amritsar to own a car.

Kiran's father, Parkash Lal, is the third of a family of four sons and three daughters, namely, sister Banarso (whose grand-daughter, Kanchan Choudhary, became the second woman IPS officer), Manohar, sister Pushpal, sister Mohinder, Manmohan and Narender. Parkash Lal was a very keen tennis player and Dr D. R. Puri (father of the famous sports commentator and surgeon Dr Narottam Puri), who was the principal of the Amritsar College, had offered him admission and a scholarship for his Bachelor of Arts on the basis of the promise he showed as a tennis player. Parkash's father,